

Lower costs for goods cut inflation in June

Much of the progress could be reversed if renewed fighting in the Mideast worsens.

By Christopher Rugaber

Inflation cooled last month as the cost of gas, clothes and used cars fell, providing some relief to consumers, while underlying price pressures also cooled more than expected.

Prices dropped 0.4% in June from May, the largest monthly drop in four years, the Labor Department said Tuesday. On a yearly basis, inflation declined to 3.5%, down from a year-over-year gain of 4.2% in May and lower than many economists expected.

Yet oil prices rose for a second day Tuesday as the United States renewed attacks on Iran and President Trump announced a new blockade in the Strait of Hormuz, a key shipping route for about one-fifth of the world's oil. Many Americans have soured on the economy after five years of elevated inflation, posing a risk to Trump and Republicans in the upcoming midterm elections.

Still, excluding the food and energy categories, core prices were unchanged in June, a positive sign that underlying inflation is cooling. On a yearly basis, core prices rose just 2.6%, down from 2.9% the previous month. Core inflation remains above the Fed's target of 2%.

A wider variety of prices cooled last month than economists had forecast. Electricity prices, which have been elevated by spiking demand from data centers, fell 1% from May to June, though they are still 4% higher than a year ago. Clothing prices dropped 0.6% from May to June but are 3.9% more expensive than a year earlier.

Groceries rose 0.2% from May to June and are up 2.7% from last year, while apartment rental costs cooled, rising just 0.1% last month and 2.8% from a year ago.

The inflation-fighters at [See Inflation, A10]



ARIANA DREHSLER For The Times



HALLINE OVERBY InsignLA

ACCLAIMED cellist Yo-Yo Ma, above, performs at an intimate concert by the Los Angeles River in late May. At top, a DJ spins records by the water.

Where currents of art and activism cross

Gentrification fears rise on banks of L.A. River

By JIREH DENG

Yo-Yo Ma closed his eyes as he drew a bow slowly across his cello, playing the first notes of the Catalan lullaby “The Song of the Birds.” But this venue wasn’t like any vaulted concert hall he had toured globally.

At Maywood’s Riverfront Park, Ma was accompanied by the vroom of nearby traffic, cascade of a yucca rainstick and burbling hum of a water synth. An oblivious biker pushed past the world-renowned classical musician. The music flowed on.

Ma’s pop-up show in southeast Los Angeles County was part of his ongoing efforts to highlight people’s relationship to nature through music. He is among a new wave of artists who have been hosting shows along the L.A. River, a waterway with a complex history.

The river once terrorized Angelenos; its unconstrained flow was prone to flooding until most of its 51 miles were lined with concrete starting in the 1940s.

While the waterway has been neglected, trashed and often forgotten over time, myriad governmental and nonprofit groups have been working for years to restore habitat, add park space and establish recreational elements (sometimes in conflict over the vision). And recently, creatives and activists, who dream of transforming it into a hospitable greenway, have been hosting arts events.

“Awareness around the river itself is changing,” said Maria Meija, executive director of L.A. River Arts, one of the organizations bringing attention to its history and cultural significance through public programming. She sees the serpentine stretch of the river as a natural highway that connects Angelenos, from the San Fernando Valley to Long Beach. “We believe that if the river is properly activated as a green and cultural landscape, then Angelenos will fundamentally also get to experience Los Angeles in a different way.” [See River, A14]

Inside the case to halt gargantuan studio merger

Paramount-Warner deal poses a big test for California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta.

By MEG JAMES

California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta's big swing — leading a coalition of 12 state attorneys general to try to block Paramount Skydance's \$13-billion takeover of Warner Bros. Discovery — could reverberate through the entertainment business for years to come.

Late Monday, Bonta's coalition of Democratic prosecutors asked a federal judge to grant a temporary restraining order to prevent tech scion David Ellison from finalizing his blockbuster acquisition of Warner Bros., which owns HBO, CNN and the Burbank studios behind such popular characters as Batman, Superman, Harry Potter and Scooby-Doo, while the case is pending.

“I am very protective of Hollywood and its ongoing durability and success,” Bonta said Tuesday during a virtual town hall. “The market is already consolidated, and additional con-

solidation will create harm.”

Winning a restraining order will be a crucial test for Bonta and his group. Some observers see the states’ efforts as an uphill climb because the U.S. Justice Department last month approved the merger. And President Trump supports the deal; he’s been rooting for a shake-up at CNN and maintains friendly ties with billionaire Larry Ellison and his son, who already own CBS.

A second battlefield emerged Tuesday when the Writers Guild of America sued in federal court to stop the merger, saying it would lead to fewer jobs and lower pay for writers.

Paramount, in a statement, blasted the lawsuit from the state attorneys general, saying it “reflects a fundamentally flawed application of the antitrust laws and is wrong on both the facts and the law.”

But the litigation poses a major headache for David Ellison, who wants to wrap up the deal by September to avoid making higher payouts to Warner Bros. Discovery shareholders and to manage escalating legal fees from a half-dozen law firms hired to help defend the [See Paramount, A10]

U.S. considers end to clock switching

House passes bill that makes daylight saving year-round. Its Senate prospects are unclear.

By IRIS KWOK

The House, in a lopsided bipartisan vote, approved a measure Tuesday to make year-round daylight saving time the default for most of the United States beginning next year.

“This legislation does exactly what Americans have been asking Congress to do, not just for years, but decades: end outdated practices of changing our clocks twice a year by making daylight savings time permanent,” Rep. Kat Cammack (R-Fla.) said on the House floor Tuesday. “It also respects the choices of states that have already opted out of daylight savings time under current law.”

The measure passed by a vote of 308 to 117. A companion bill is still being debated in the Senate, where its prospects are uncertain.

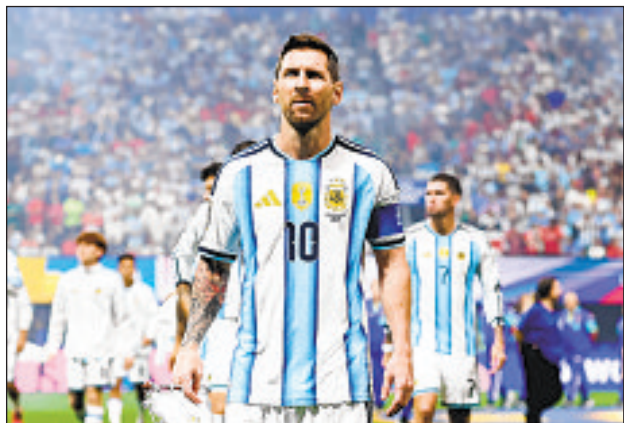
Lawmakers in California

and other states could opt out of making daylight saving time permanent but would need to decide before the law takes effect, Josh Gregory, a senior advisor to Rep. Vern Buchanan (R-Fla.), the sponsor of H.R. 139, said in an email.

The debate over the year-round mandate centered on potential health issues and its impact on sleep, businesses, agriculture and outdoor recreation, particularly golf courses. President Trump, who owns several courses, supported the bill.

At a hearing Tuesday, Rep. Mary Gay Scanlon (D-Pa.) said the bill “chooses the wrong solution.” Its passage, she said, would mean “millions of Americans will wake up during the winter months in complete darkness, with the sun not rising until long after people get up and travel to school or work” and have a number of negative health impacts.

Most of the country went on daylight saving time in the spring, moving clocks one hour ahead of standard time. The bill would end the “fall back” to standard time [See Clock, A7]



JUSTIN SETTERFIELD Getty Images

THE VENERABLE Lionel Messi of Argentina will play in his third World Cup semifinal on Wednesday.

World Cup stars are defying Father Time

By KEVIN BAXTER

While every World Cup introduces viewers to new young stars, this tournament featured eight players who were older than 40 — one more than the number of over-40 players in the previous 22 World Cups combined.

Among them were Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo, 41, and Mexico's Memo Ochoa, 40, who were playing in their sixth World Cups alongside Argentina's Lionel Messi, a relative youngster at 39. No

one has played in more men's World Cups.

But while Ronaldo and Ochoa have gone home, Messi will be playing in his third semifinal in four tournaments Wednesday when Argentina, the reigning champion, faces England at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta.

The newfound longevity of elite soccer players has been made possible by advances in sports medicine, diet and analytics that measure everything from biomechanics and heart rate to [See World Cup, A3]

Illness stirs up fears of tainted produce

As cyclosporiasis spreads, experts advise thoroughly washing fruit, veggies.

By KAREN GARCIA AND HANNAH FRY

A surge in parasitic disease cases that can cause a prolonged bout of debilitating diarrhea is prompting growing concerns from public health officials and questions from the public about the safety of fresh produce.

Experts say the risk varies in different parts of the country. In California, basic washing of produce remains sufficient, they said. California has reported 41 cases of cyclosporiasis this year, but none of them have been linked to a recent multistate outbreak, according to local public health officials. The situation in other states is more concerning.

Cyclosporiasis is an intestinal illness caused by the microscopic parasite *Cyclospora cayentanensis*, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. People contract the illness by consuming food or water contaminated with the feces of a person infected by the parasite.

The epicenter of the cyclosporiasis outbreak is in Michigan, where the state public health department has reported more than 3,000 cases of the illness, including 44 cases requiring hospitalization.

On Tuesday, the Michigan health department said, “available information indicates that lettuce or salad greens may be a potential source of this outbreak”; however, other food items cannot be completely ruled out.

In the U.S., food-borne outbreaks of cyclosporiasis have been linked to various types of fresh produce imported from Latin America, including raspberries, cilantro, basil, snow peas and mixed salad, according to the California Department of Public Health.

At least 34 states have separately reported between tens and hundreds of cases of cyclosporiasis this summer.

Since May 1, the CDC has received more than 1,600 confirmed domestic cases and is aware of more than 5,100 cases that require further analysis to confirm the illness as domestically acquired cyclosporiasis.

Officials say the true number of cases is likely [See Illness, A14]



RYAN MURPHY Getty Images

ICE PAUSES VEHICLE STOPS

A makeshift memorial honors a man killed by ICE in Maine. The agency's temporary order comes after two deadly encounters. **NATION, A6**

UC hastens SAT reconsideration

Amid concerns about college readiness, faculty have until June 2027 for a major policy review. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Very warm.

L.A. Basin: 92/70. **B6**

Markets **A10**

Opinion Voices **A12**

Placing bets on reality TV

Nearly \$24 million was riding on “Love Island USA” finale in a Kalshi market. **BUSINESS, A8**

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FIRST FINALIST: Spain shuts out France 2-0 in a dominating performance in Texas. **SPORTS, B10**